



KASHIGO

2026 EDITION



INDIA SCAM-PROOF

The First-Timer's Field Manual

Every common tourist scam, the real prices, and the exact words to say.

VAIBHAV UPADHYAY

India Scam-Proof

The First-Timer's Field Manual — 2026 Edition



VAIBHAV UPADHYAY • KASHIGO

KASHIGO • VARANASI • 2026

India Scam-Proof: The First-Timer's Field Manual — 2026 Edition

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How to Use This Book

I grew up in the lanes of Kashi — Varanasi, if you are reading the map — a few minutes' walk from the river. As a boy I sold nothing and guided no one, but I watched. I watched the man with the laminated "official boat price list" that he had printed himself. I watched the friendly young "student" who only wanted to practise his English, right up until the moment he walked a couple from Germany into his cousin's silk shop. I watched travellers who had saved for years arrive at the ghats wide-eyed and leave three days later tired, suspicious and poorer than they needed to be.

Most of those travellers were not foolish. They were simply new. They did not know the prices, the rules, or the scripts. This book gives you all three.

India is not a dangerous country for tourists in the way people fear. The overwhelming majority of what goes wrong for first-timers is not violence. It is money: small overcharges, bigger commission traps, and a

handful of genuinely elaborate cons. The good news is that they are predictable. The same twenty or thirty patterns repeat from Delhi to Goa to Kerala. Learn the patterns once and you are protected for the whole trip.

How this book is organised

The early chapters follow your journey in order: arrival, money, transport. Then come the city-by-city scam maps, so you can read the Delhi section on the plane and the Jaipur section on the train. After that, themed chapters on temples, shopping, accommodation, digital scams, women's safety and health. At the end you will find the parts you will actually use on the street: **The Scripts** (exact phrases in English and Hindi), **The Price Tables**, and **If You Do Get Scammed**.

Every scam in this book follows the same layout so you can scan it in ten seconds:

- **How it works** — the mechanics, step by step.
- **Red flags** — the signals that tell you it is starting.
- **Your move** — what to do, practically.
- **Say this** — the exact words, so you are not improvising under pressure.

A note on prices

Every price in this book is a 2026 range, not a promise. India changes fast. Fuel prices move, cities revise auto fares, monuments revise tickets. Treat the numbers as a compass, not a contract. Where something is official (a monument ticket, a government website), I tell you where to check it. Where something is negotiated, I give you a fair range and the reasoning behind it, so you can adjust in the moment.

LOCAL TIP

You do not need to win every negotiation. Overpaying ₹50 on an auto ride is not a scam worth your peace of mind. This book is about stopping the ₹5,000 mistakes, not about fighting over the price of chai.

A note on fairness

Most Indians you meet will never try to cheat you. The chai seller, the family sharing your train compartment, the shopkeeper who refuses your extra coins — they are the real India, and you will meet far more of them than the people in this book. Scams cluster in a small number of places: airports, railway stations, the famous monuments, and the lanes around them. Step a few streets away and the whole tone changes.

Be alert. Do not be cold. The goal of this book is to let you relax.



The One Rule Behind Every Scam

Before we go city by city, I want to give you a single idea that will protect you from scams I have not even written about yet — the new ones that will be invented after this book is printed.

Almost every tourist scam in India is built from two ingredients:

1. **Unasked-for help.** Someone approaches you and offers something you did not request: directions, information, a "better" price, a free tour, an explanation of a ritual, a warning that your hotel is closed.
2. **An information gap.** They know something you do not — the real price, the real rules, where the real ticket office is, whether the temple is actually open.

When both are present at once, your guard should go up. Not because the person is definitely a scammer, but because that is exactly the situation scams need to work.

The three-second test

When a stranger approaches you with help, ask yourself three quick questions:

1. **Did I ask for this?** If not, the help has a price somewhere.
2. **Is there a deadline?** "Hurry, the office closes in ten minutes." "Only today." "The last boat is leaving." Real deadlines exist, but fake urgency is the scammer's favourite tool.
3. **Can I verify this myself?** Can you check the app, phone your hotel, walk to the official counter, or simply wait five minutes? If yes, do that instead.

If the answers are "no, yes, yes" — walk away politely.

Why it works on smart people

Scams in India are rarely crude. The best operators are charming, funny and genuinely knowledgeable. They read your accent, your shoes, your guidebook. They know you are jet-lagged and that you do not want to be rude. Many of them start with something true and useful — a real piece of history, a real shortcut — so that by the time the ask comes, you already like them.

That is why the rule is about the *structure*, not the person. You do not have to decide whether someone is a good human being. You only have to notice: unasked help plus information gap. Then you slow down.

The power of the slow "no"

The most effective anti-scam technique in India costs nothing: a calm, friendly, unhurried refusal, repeated as many times as needed, while you keep walking.

You do not need to explain. You do not need to argue. Explaining gives the other person something to negotiate with. "No thank you, I'm fine" —

smile — keep moving. If they follow, say it again, exactly the same way. Most touts give up within twenty metres because you are no longer worth their time.

SAY THIS

"No thank you, I'm fine." / "Nahi chahiye, shukriya." (I don't need it, thank you.)

What this book will not do

It will not turn you into a suspicious, joyless traveller who refuses every kindness. Indians are famously hospitable, and some of your best memories will start with a stranger starting a conversation. The difference is simple: genuine hospitality does not lead to a shop, a ledger, a ticket booth or a "small donation". Once you know where the scams lead, you can enjoy the conversations that do not.



CHAPTER 1

Arrival

The first two hours in India are when you are most vulnerable. You are tired, possibly disoriented by the heat or the cold or the noise, your phone may not work yet, you have no rupees, and you do not know what anything costs. Every tout at the airport knows this. That is why the arrival hall and the first taxi ride produce more scam stories than almost anything else.

The fix is preparation. If you have your first night's hotel booked, your transport decided, and a little cash or a working payment method before you land, you remove almost every arrival scam in one move.

Before you land: the 10-minute setup

Do these things at home, on Wi-Fi:

- **Save your hotel's address and phone number** offline (a screenshot is fine). Message the hotel through the booking platform

to confirm your arrival time.

- **Ask the hotel about a pickup.** Many hotels offer airport transfers for a fixed price. It is often slightly more than a prepaid taxi, but for a late-night first arrival it is worth it.
- **Download Uber and Ola** (and Rapido if you are comfortable with app autos and bikes). Set them up with your email and an international card while you still have your home SIM.
- **Download offline maps** for your arrival city in Google Maps.
- **Carry a small amount of rupees if you can get them**, or plan to use an ATM inside the arrivals hall. (Rules on carrying Indian currency in and out of India for foreign visitors are restrictive and change from time to time — check the current rules with your bank or India's customs website before relying on rupees bought abroad.)

Delhi IGI Airport

Indira Gandhi International Airport is modern and well-run. Inside the terminal you are safe. The issues begin at the exit doors.

The arrivals hall taxi tout

How it works: As you walk out with your luggage, men approach you saying "Taxi? Taxi, sir? Madam, very cheap." Some wear lanyards or vaguely official jackets. They lead you to a private car in the car park and either quote a high price (often several times the normal fare), or quote a normal price and then add "parking", "toll" and "airport fee" on arrival. Some of these drivers are the ones who later tell you your hotel is closed.

Red flags: Anyone who approaches you first. Anyone who walks you away from the official taxi rank. A car with no visible company branding and no meter. A driver who wants to "keep your bag in the boot" before agreeing a price.

Your move: Do not accept transport from anyone who approaches you. Choose one of three clean options: the official prepaid taxi counter inside

the arrivals area (run under police supervision at Delhi), an app cab booked yourself from the designated pickup zone, or your hotel's pre-arranged driver holding a sign with your name.

SAY THIS

"No thank you, I have a car booked." (Even if you haven't yet. It ends the conversation.)

The prepaid taxi counter

The Delhi prepaid taxi booths operate under the supervision of the Delhi Traffic Police. You tell the counter your destination, pay a fixed fare, and receive a slip. You hand that slip to the driver at the end of the ride, not the beginning — the slip is his proof of the job, so keeping it until you arrive is your leverage.

Typical 2026 fares from IGI to central areas such as Connaught Place, Paharganj or New Delhi Railway Station are in the region of ₹500–900 for a standard car, depending on terminal, vehicle type and time of day. Night surcharges (usually late night to early morning) are common. If you are quoted ₹2,500 for Paharganj at a counter, you are at the wrong counter.

Red flags at the counter itself: Several private companies also have desks in the arrivals hall. They are legitimate businesses, but they are more expensive, and some men loitering around them are freelancers. Look for the counter that is clearly labelled as prepaid or police-run, and check that you receive a printed receipt.

App cabs (Uber, Ola) at the airport

App cabs work well at Delhi and Mumbai airports, and the fare is shown before you book. At Delhi Terminal 3, app pickups happen in a designated zone in the multi-level car park area rather than at the kerb — follow the signs, and expect a short walk and sometimes a 15–25 minute

wait at busy times. Surge pricing can make app fares higher than the prepaid counter at peak hours, so compare both.

The app-cab traps to watch for:

- **"Cancel and pay me cash."** The driver calls you, says the app pays him badly, and asks you to cancel the ride and pay cash "at the same price". Once you cancel, you lose the GPS record, the fare guarantee and the in-app safety features. Politely refuse.
- **The wrong car.** Always match the number plate to the app before you put your bag in. Ask "Who are you here for?" rather than saying your own name first.
- **The off-trip "toll and parking" add-on.** Tolls and airport parking may be added to app fares legitimately — but they appear in the app. Do not pay cash extras on top of what the app shows, unless the app itself tells you to.

SAY THIS

"No cash, sir. App se payment hoga." (Payment will be through the app.)

The Delhi Airport Express metro

If you arrive in daylight with light luggage, the Airport Express metro line from Terminal 3 to central Delhi is fast, cheap (well under ₹100) and scam-free. It connects to New Delhi Railway Station, which is useful if you are staying in Paharganj. At the other end you will still need a short auto or app ride — and that is where the next scams wait.

Mumbai Airport

Mumbai's international terminal (Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj International, Terminal 2) has a similar layout: prepaid taxi counters, app pickup zones and private desks. App cabs work well. Mumbai's

black-and-yellow taxis are usually metered in the city, but from the airport you are better off with a prepaid slip or an app ride, particularly at night.

Fares from the airport to South Mumbai (Colaba, Fort) can be significant because of distance and traffic — budget roughly ₹600–1,200 by app or prepaid car depending on time of day and surge, and more if you are using a premium car. Areas like Bandra and Andheri are much closer and cheaper.

The Mumbai-specific trick is the "luggage helper": a man who grabs your trolley, pushes it twenty metres to a car and then demands a tip. A small tip is fine if you actually wanted the help. If you did not, keep a hand on your trolley.

SAY THIS

"Main khud le jaunga, shukriya." (I'll take it myself, thanks.)
Women would say *"le jaungi"*.

Other airports

Smaller airports — Varanasi, Jaipur, Agra, Goa, Kochi — usually have a prepaid taxi counter or a fixed-rate taxi stand. In Varanasi, a prepaid taxi from Lal Bahadur Shastri Airport to the city typically costs around ₹800–1,000; the drive takes 45 minutes to over an hour depending on traffic and exactly where you are going (cars cannot enter the narrowest lanes of the old city, so you will walk the last stretch). App cabs operate at most of these airports too, but coverage and pickup rules vary — check before you land.

The "Your Hotel Is Closed" Scam

This is one of the oldest scams in India and it is still running, especially in Delhi and Varanasi, and especially at night.

The closed / burned-down / overbooked hotel

How it works: Your driver — airport taxi, train-station auto, or someone who "helps" you with directions — tells you there is a problem with your hotel. It is closed for a festival. There was a fire. The area is blocked because of a riot or a VIP visit. The hotel is overbooked. Sometimes he makes a phone call "to the hotel" and hands you the phone; the person on the other end (his friend) confirms the bad news. Then he kindly offers to take you to "a very good hotel, same price". That hotel pays him a commission, and you pay double. Some versions also deliver you to a "tourist office" that books you an expensive package tour.

Red flags: Any bad news about your booking that comes from the driver rather than from the hotel itself. A driver who calls the hotel on his own phone. Talk of riots, fires, curfews or festival closures you have not seen in the news. Taking a longer route than your map shows.

Your move: Never let the driver call the hotel for you. Call the number you saved yourself, or message through the booking app. Insist on being taken to the address you booked. If he refuses, ask him to stop in a busy area, pay him the fair amount for the distance travelled, and get an app cab. If you used a prepaid taxi, he has not been paid yet — the slip in your hand is your leverage.

SAY THIS

*"I will call the hotel myself. Please take me to this address." Then:
"Isi address pe chalo." (Go to this address.)*

LOCAL TIP

Before you land, message your hotel: "I'm arriving at 11pm. If a driver tells me you are closed, I'll call you." Hotels in tourist areas know this scam well and will often send you a WhatsApp voice note or a photo of the front desk. It is reassuring when you need it most.

New Delhi Railway Station and Paharganj

New Delhi Railway Station (often written as NDLS) sits right next to Paharganj, Delhi's backpacker district. It is also, for a first-timer, the most intense scam zone in the country. Read this section twice if you are taking a train from Delhi.

The "office upstairs" train ticket scam

How it works: As you approach the station entrance, a man — sometimes in a uniform-like shirt, sometimes holding a clipboard or a lanyard — stops you and asks to see your ticket. He tells you that foreign tourists cannot book here, or that your e-ticket is "not confirmed" and must be "validated", or that the foreign tourist booking office has moved / is closed / is under renovation. He points you to a "government tourist office" across the road or "upstairs" in a nearby building. There, a polite man at a desk with an official-looking sign tells you the trains are full and sells you an overpriced private car tour or a train ticket with a huge markup.

Red flags: Anyone outside the station asking to see your ticket. Any claim that a booking office has moved. Being led out of the station building, across a road or into a side street. Signs that say "Government Approved", "Tourist Information" or "India Tourism" on a shopfront in Paharganj or Connaught Place. Real railway staff work inside stations; they do not recruit customers from the pavement.

Your move: Know the truth before you arrive. At New Delhi Railway Station there is a genuine International Tourist Bureau inside the main station building — on the upper floor on the Paharganj side — where foreign visitors with passports can book from the foreign tourist quota. It is inside the station, not across the street. If you already hold an e-ticket from the official IRCTC website or app, it does not need any "validation" from anyone. Walk past anyone who stops you outside, go inside, and check the departure boards yourself.

SAY THIS

"I already have my ticket, thank you." Keep walking. If they insist: "Main station ke andar poochh lunga." (I'll ask inside the station.)

The fake tourist office

How it works: In Paharganj, Connaught Place and around Janpath you will see small shops with signs like "Govt. Regd. Tourist Information Centre" or names that sound like a national tourism body. Rickshaw drivers will bring you there for free. Inside, the staff are friendly and helpful and will build you an entire North India itinerary — car, driver, hotels, Agra, Jaipur — at two to four times the fair price, often paid in full upfront. The trip may happen, but with poor hotels and endless shopping stops.

Red flags: Any "tourist office" you were brought to by a driver. Pressure to pay the full amount today. Offices that say trains are "all full for two weeks" (you can check this yourself in seconds on the IRCTC app or a train-status app). Prices given only as a package, never itemised.

Your move: The official India Tourism (Government of India) office in Delhi is in a government building, not on a backpacker street, and it does not sell packages. You do not need a tourist office to travel India. If you want a car and driver, get quotes from two or three operators recommended by your hotel or found through recent reviews, ask for an

itemised price, and pay a small deposit rather than everything up front.

SAY THIS

"Thank you, I'll book it myself online." / "Main khud book kar lunga." (I'll book it myself.) Women say "kar lungi".

The "your e-ticket is waitlisted, I can fix it" trick

How it works: Someone looks at your ticket and says it is on a waiting list (WL) and you will not get a seat — but he can get you a confirmed seat for a fee. Sometimes this is half true: waitlisted tickets do exist. But he is not a railway official and cannot change your status.

Red flags: A stranger reading your ticket for you. Talk of "fixing" or "upgrading" a booking for cash. No uniform, no railway office, no receipt.

Your move: Check your PNR (the 10-digit booking number) yourself in the IRCTC app or any reputable train-status app. If you are genuinely waitlisted on an e-ticket that does not confirm by the time the final chart is prepared, the ticket is normally cancelled automatically and refunded under railway rules. The real fix is booking earlier or using the foreign tourist quota (see the Transport chapter).

SAY THIS

"I'll check my PNR myself, thank you."

Your first night: a simple arrival plan

If you are nervous, use this sequence and you will avoid nearly everything in this chapter:

1. Book your first night in advance and pay through a reputable platform or directly to the hotel.

2. Arrange a hotel pickup, or use the prepaid counter, or book an app cab from the official pickup zone — never a man who approaches you.
3. Withdraw a modest amount of cash from an ATM inside the arrivals hall.
4. Buy a SIM at the airport if a counter is open, or rely on hotel Wi-Fi for the first night and buy one the next day (see the Digital chapter).
5. Do not let anyone call your hotel for you.
6. Sleep. Every scam in India is easier to spot after a night's rest.



CHAPTER 2

Money

Money is where most scams happen, so getting your money setup right is the single biggest protection you can give yourself. The goal is simple: always have a mix of payment options, always have small notes, and always know roughly what something should cost before you pay for it.

Cash, cards and UPI: what actually works in 2026

India has changed enormously in the last few years. Small shops, chai stalls and even some street vendors now accept payment by scanning a QR code using UPI (Unified Payments Interface), the national instant-payment system. Indians use it for almost everything.

For foreign visitors, the picture is mixed:

- **Cash** is still essential. Autos, cycle rickshaws, boatmen, small temples, street food, tips and markets often prefer cash, and many will only take cash.
- **International cards** (Visa, Mastercard; American Express less widely) work in hotels, mid-range and upscale restaurants, chain stores, malls, larger shops and for booking travel online. Small shops often do not take them, or add a surcharge.
- **UPI for foreigners** is possible but not as simple as it is for Indians. The government payments body (NPCI) has launched a prepaid wallet option called **UPI One World** for international visitors, issued through authorised providers — for example through an app you download, verify with your passport and visa, and top up with an international card. It has been offered at some major international airports and through partner apps, and eligibility and availability have changed since it was first launched. Check the current situation shortly before your trip rather than relying on it. If you can set it up, it is genuinely useful for small payments; if not, cash and cards will cover you.

LOCAL TIP

If a QR payment fails or you cannot use UPI, never let a shopkeeper "help" by taking your phone. Pay in cash instead. You should be the only person who touches your phone during a payment.

ATMs

ATMs are everywhere in cities and tourist towns. A few practical rules:

- **Use ATMs inside bank branches, airports, malls or hotels**, ideally during the day. Standalone kiosks on quiet streets are more likely to be tampered with or out of cash.
- **Expect withdrawal limits.** Many Indian ATMs limit foreign cards to around ₹10,000 per withdrawal (some allow more). Each withdrawal may carry a local fee plus your home bank's fee, so taking

out larger amounts fewer times is usually cheaper.

- **Decline "dynamic currency conversion".** If the ATM or a card machine offers to charge you "in your home currency", say no and choose rupees (INR). The "convenient" conversion almost always uses a worse exchange rate.
- **Tell your bank you are travelling** and carry at least two cards from different banks, kept in different places.

The ATM helper

How it works: A friendly man at the ATM says the machine is tricky, or that your card is stuck, or he stands just behind you while you type your PIN. A common variation: your card gets "stuck", he tells you to call a "helpline number" stuck to the machine (fake), or he swaps your card for a similar-looking one while "helping". He or his partner then uses your card with the PIN he watched you type.

Red flags: Anyone offering help at an ATM. Anyone standing close behind you. Stickers with "helpline numbers" on the machine. A card slot that looks loose, bulky or different.

Your move: Cover the keypad with your other hand every time. If your card is genuinely swallowed, call your bank using the number on its official website or app — not any number on the machine — and freeze the card from your banking app. Do not leave the machine with a stranger "watching" it for you.

SAY THIS

*"No, thank you. Please step back." / "Peechhe hatiye, please."
(Please step back.)*

Money changers

Exchanging cash is simple at airports, banks and authorised money changers (licensed businesses usually display their authorisation). Airport rates are often poor; licensed changers in tourist areas are usually better. Hotels are convenient but expensive.

The counting trick

How it works: The changer counts your rupees in front of you, quickly, then folds the stack and hands it over. Somewhere during the folding, a few notes disappear into his palm or under the counter. You count later and are short.

Red flags: Fast counting, folding the stack before handing it over, distractions mid-count, no receipt.

Your move: Count the money yourself, slowly, at the counter, before you leave. Ask for a receipt. Licensed changers should give you one. If the count is wrong, say so immediately and calmly.

SAY THIS

"Let me count it, please." / "Main ginti kar leta hoon." (I'll count it.)

Knowing your notes

Indian notes come in ₹10, ₹20, ₹50, ₹100, ₹200 and ₹500 denominations. Coins come in ₹1, ₹2, ₹5, ₹10 and ₹20. The ₹2,000 note was withdrawn from circulation in 2023 — if anyone tries to give you one in change, refuse it.

Small notes are gold. Break ₹500 notes at hotels, supermarkets, petrol stations, pharmacies and train-station food counters whenever you can, so you always have ₹10s, ₹20s and ₹50s for autos, chai and small

purchases. Many auto drivers and vendors genuinely cannot change a ₹500 — and some pretend they cannot, hoping you will tell them to keep the change.

The Rs 500 switch

How it works: You hand over a ₹500 note. The vendor or driver turns away for a moment, then turns back holding a ₹100 note and says, "Sir, you gave me 100." Or he quickly swaps your good note for a torn or old note and says yours is "not accepted". The notes are different colours, but in a dim lane at night, with the man looking hurt and confused, many travellers doubt themselves.

Red flags: The person turns away or moves the note out of your sight. Nightfall, crowds, rushing.

Your move: When you hand over a large note, say its value out loud — "Five hundred" — and keep looking at the note until change is in your hand. Better still, pay with smaller notes. If you are sure, stay calm and firm; scammers count on you giving up.

SAY THIS

"Paanch sau ka note diya hai." (I gave you a five hundred note.)

The short-change and "no change" game

How it works: You pay with a ₹200 note for a ₹70 item. The seller gives you ₹30 back and waits to see if you notice. Or he says "no change" and hopes you will let it go.

Red flags: Change handed over quickly while you are distracted, or a sudden claim of "no change" only after you have handed over a big note.

Your move: Count change before you walk away. If he truly has no change, he can ask the shop next door — this is completely normal in India. Do not let it become a tip by default.

SAY THIS

"Change chahiye, please." (I need change, please.) / "Baaki paise?" (The rest of the money?)

The MRP rule: your secret weapon

Every packaged product sold in India — bottled water, soft drinks, biscuits, crisps, sunscreen, medicines, toiletries — must by law have an **MRP (Maximum Retail Price)** printed on the label. It includes all taxes. A shop may sell below MRP, but may not legally charge more than it.

This is incredibly useful. At tourist sites, vendors often ask ₹40 or ₹50 for a bottle of water marked ₹20. Turn the bottle around, find the "MRP ₹" on the label, and pay exactly that.

Some places selling chilled drinks add a "cooling charge". That is not a legal reason to charge above MRP, although in hotels, restaurants, airports and some special venues the rules and prices differ. For a street-side shop, MRP is the price.

SAY THIS

"MRP pe dijiye." (Give it to me at MRP.) Pointing at the label works just as well.

Tipping norms

Tipping in India is appreciated but not as rigid as in the US. A sensible 2026 guide:

Situation	Typical tip	Notes
Restaurant (casual)	Round up, or ₹20–50	Many locals do not tip at cheap eateries
Restaurant (mid-range / upscale)	5–10%	Only if no service charge is already on the bill
Hotel porter	₹50–100 per stay or per bag set	More at luxury hotels
Housekeeping	₹50–100 per night, left at the end	Optional; appreciated
Driver (full day hire)	₹200–500 per day	Only for good service, at the end of the trip
Licensed guide (half day)	₹200–500	On top of the agreed fee, if you were happy
Boatman	₹50–100	If the ride was good and on time
App cab / auto	Not expected	Rounding up is kind

Service charge: some restaurants add a "service charge" line to the bill. Under Indian consumer guidelines, a service charge cannot be made compulsory — you can ask for it to be removed. If it stays, do not tip on top.

The bargaining playbook

Bargaining is normal in markets, with autos (where there is no meter), with boatmen and with freelance guides. It is not normal in malls, fixed-price shops, supermarkets, pharmacies, restaurants or anywhere with a printed price tag or MRP.

The percentages

These are rough guidelines for tourist-area markets. They are not rules; they are a starting point.

Situation	Typical first quote to tourists	Your opening offer	A fair landing zone
Souvenir stalls, tourist markets	2–4× the fair price	30–40% of quote	50–60% of quote
Textiles in tourist shops	2–3×	40% of quote	50–70% of quote
Autos without meter	1.5–3×	Roughly the app fare	App fare to app fare + 20%
Boatmen (Varanasi)	2–4×	Low end of fair range	Within fair range
Fixed-price emporiums	Fixed	Do not bargain	Price tag

How to bargain without stress

1. **Know your number before you ask the price.** Check an app, the price tables in this book, or ask your hotel. Decide what you are willing to pay.
2. **Ask the price first. Never offer first.**
3. **React calmly.** A small laugh and "Bahut zyada hai" (that's too much) is all you need.
4. **Make one counter-offer and stay near it.** Do not jump up in big steps.
5. **Be ready to walk away — and actually walk.** This is the single most powerful move. If your price was fair, you will often be called back before you have gone five steps.
6. **Once you agree, pay that exact amount.** Re-opening an agreed price is bad manners on either side.

SAY THIS

"Kitne ka hai?" (How much is it?) □ "Bahut zyada hai." (That's too much.) □ "Theek daam bataiye." (Tell me the right price.) □ "Main [amount] doonga." (I'll give [amount].) □ "Chaliye, rehne dijiye." (Okay, never mind.) — and walk.

LOCAL TIP

Shopkeepers respect a customer who bargains with humour. Smile, joke, take your time. The ones who get angry or offended when you walk away are usually the ones who quoted you the most outrageous price.



CHAPTER 3

Transport

India's transport is one of its great adventures. You will ride in autos with three wheels and a thousand opinions, sleep on trains that cross half a continent, and occasionally wonder how a cycle rickshaw driver can carry two adults and their luggage through a lane barely wider than the rickshaw. Almost all of it is safe and fairly priced if you follow a few rules.

Auto-rickshaws

Autos (also called tuk-tuks or three-wheelers) are everywhere. In some cities — Mumbai is the best example — autos use their meters as a matter of routine. In many others, including Delhi, Agra, Jaipur and Varanasi, meters exist on paper but drivers usually quote a fixed price, especially to tourists.

The no-meter overcharge

How it works: You ask the driver to use the meter. He says it is broken, or that the meter is "only for locals", or he just names a price two or three times the fair rate.

Red flags: A covered or missing meter. A price quoted before you have even said where you are going. "Sir, for you, special price."

Your move: Check the fare on Uber, Ola or Rapido (even if you do not book through the app, it gives you a benchmark). Then either insist on the meter, or agree a fixed price close to the app price **before you get in**. Name the exact destination — not just the neighbourhood.

SAY THIS

"Meter se chalo." (Go by meter.) If there's no meter: "Kitna loge, [destination] tak?" (How much will you take to [destination]?)

The detour to a shop

How it works: Your driver suddenly says he must make a "quick stop" — for petrol, to pick up a friend, or because "this famous shop is government-approved, just look, no buy". Or he offers you a very cheap day tour, sometimes ₹100 or ₹200 for the whole day, and then spends that day taking you to shops that pay him commission. Many drivers also receive small payments or fuel coupons just for bringing a tourist through the door, even if you buy nothing.

Red flags: "Just five minutes, no buy." An unusually cheap all-day price. A sudden claim that your destination is closed.

Your move: Agree before you get in: "No shops, only [destination]." If he stops anyway, stay in the vehicle and repeat it. If he refuses to continue, pay for the distance travelled and take another auto. A ridiculously cheap all-day tour is never really cheap.

SAY THIS

"Koi dukaan nahi. Seedha [destination] chalo." (No shops. Go straight to [destination].)

The "fifty" that becomes "fifty each"

How it works: You agree "fifty rupees". At the end, the driver says it was fifty *per person*, or fifty *dollars*, or a different number that sounds similar in English (fifteen/fifty, thirty/thirteen).

Red flags: A vague answer when you ask "total?". Numbers that sound alike in English (fifteen/fifty). Any hesitation when you confirm.

Your move: Confirm with your fingers or by showing the note: "Total fifty, two people." For larger amounts, say the number in Hindi or type it on your phone screen and show him.

SAY THIS

"Total pachaas, dono ke liye." (Total fifty, for both of us.)

Cycle rickshaws

Cycle rickshaws are still common in Varanasi, Old Delhi (around Chandni Chowk), Agra and many smaller cities. They are perfect for short trips through crowded lanes where cars cannot go. They almost never have meters, so agree the price first.

Fair short rides (1–2 km) in 2026 typically cost ₹50–150 depending on the city, distance, load and time of day. Pay a little more for a hilly route, heavy bags or extreme heat — these men work hard for very little. The scams are the same as autos: shop detours and "per person" surprises.

Uber, Ola and Rapido

App-based rides are the easiest way for a first-timer to avoid fare negotiations in big cities. You see the price before you book, there is a GPS record, and you can share your trip with someone.

- **Uber and Ola** cover most major cities with cars and, in many cities, autos as well.
- **Rapido** offers bike taxis (you ride pillion on a motorbike), autos and cabs in many cities. Bike taxis are cheap and fast in traffic, but think honestly about your comfort with road safety before choosing one. Always wear the helmet offered.
- **In Goa**, app-cab coverage has historically been limited because of local taxi rules; there is a state-backed taxi app and local taxi stands. Ask your hotel what works on the ground when you arrive.

App-ride tricks

- **"Cancel, I'll take you for cash."** Covered in the Arrival chapter. Always refuse.
- **"Your location is wrong, it will cost more."** Sometimes true, often not. If the driver demands extra, offer to rebook rather than pay cash on top.
- **"AC extra."** On a regular car booking, AC is generally expected. Asking for an extra fee to switch it on is not standard. You can report it in the app.
- **Ending the trip early in the app.** Keep the app open until you arrive. If the driver ends the trip before your destination, you may be charged a different fare or he may ask for cash for the "rest".

Trains

Indian Railways is one of the world's largest rail networks, and riding it is one of the best experiences in the country. It is also where many first-timers lose money to touts.

The basics

- **Book through IRCTC** (Indian Railway Catering and Tourism Corporation), the official railway booking website and app. Foreign visitors can register with an international mobile number and email, and pay with international cards for **Foreign Tourist Quota** bookings. Registration has historically involved some verification steps that can be fiddly; allow time and do it before your trip if possible.
- **Foreign Tourist Quota** is a small reserved allocation of seats for foreign passport holders on many popular trains, generally in the higher classes (such as AC First, AC 2-Tier and Executive Chair Car). You can book it online through IRCTC's foreign tourist booking option, or in person at designated booking offices in major stations — such as the International Tourist Bureau at New Delhi Railway Station — with your passport.
- **Your PNR** (a 10-digit number) is your booking reference. Check its status in the IRCTC app or a reputable train-status app.

Classes, in plain English

Class code	What it is	Who it suits
1A	AC First Class, lockable cabins of 2 or 4 berths	Comfort, privacy, couples, solo women
2A	AC 2-Tier, open bays with curtains, 4–6 berths	Excellent balance of comfort and price
3A	AC 3-Tier, open bays, more berths, no curtains	Good value, busier
SL	Sleeper, non-AC, open windows	Budget backpackers; crowded, intense
CC / EC	AC Chair Car / Executive Chair Car (day trains)	Shatabdi, Vande Bharat and similar fast day trains
GN / 2S	General / Second Sitting, unreserved	Not recommended for first-timers

For a first trip, 2A or 3A on overnight trains and CC or EC on day trains is the sweet spot.

Tatkal

Tatkal is a last-minute booking quota that opens the day before travel at a fixed time, and the best seats sell out in minutes. Since 2025, online Tatkal booking has required Aadhaar-based authentication of the user account — and Aadhaar is the Indian national ID, which visitors normally do not have. In practice, foreign visitors should not count on Tatkal. Use the Foreign Tourist Quota or book well in advance instead. Anyone who promises "guaranteed Tatkal for foreigners" for a large fee is selling something you should not need.

The fake ticket checker

How it works: On the platform or on the train, a man asks to see your ticket and announces that it is wrong — wrong class, wrong train, not valid for foreigners, missing a stamp — and that you must pay a "fine" in cash, right now.

Red flags: No uniform or name badge, no handheld device or official receipt book, insistence on cash, and the "fine" amount is negotiable. Real Travelling Ticket Examiners (TTEs) wear uniforms — typically a black coat in many zones — and carry name badges and official charts or devices. Genuine penalties come with an official receipt.

Your move: Show your PNR on your phone. Ask for his name and ID, and say you will pay any fine only with an official receipt. Ask other passengers — Indian travellers know exactly how this works and will often step in on your behalf.

SAY THIS

*"Receipt dijiye, tab doonga." (Give me a receipt, then I'll pay.) /
"Aapka ID dikhaiye." (Show me your ID.)*

The porter overcharge

How it works: Station porters (coolies, in red shirts with a numbered brass armband) are licensed and genuinely useful. But they often lift your bags first and name a price later — several times the usual rate for foreigners.

Red flags: Bags lifted before a price is agreed. A price "per bag" that becomes "per trip" at the end.

Your move: Agree a total before anyone touches your luggage. ₹100–300 for a couple of bags to a platform is reasonable at most stations; more for long distances or heavy loads.

SAY THIS

"Do bag, platform tak, total kitna?" (Two bags, to the platform, how much in total?)

The "your train is cancelled" tout

How it works: Outside a station, someone tells you your train is cancelled or delayed by many hours, and offers a taxi or bus instead.

Red flags: Bad news from someone outside the station. An immediate offer of a taxi, bus or "tourist office" to solve it.

Your move: Check the live train status yourself in the IRCTC app or a train-status app, and look at the departure boards inside the station. Trains in India do get delayed, especially in winter fog in the north — but you should hear about it from the railway, not from a stranger.

SAY THIS

"Main board dekh lunga." (I'll check the board myself.) Women say "dekh lungi".

Buses

Long-distance buses connect almost every city. Government state transport buses are cheap and generally reliable; private "Volvo" or sleeper coaches are more comfortable. Book through the state transport corporation's site, reputable bus-booking apps, or a recommendation from your hotel.

The common bus problems are not dramatic scams but frustrations: buses that leave late, a "luxury sleeper" that turns out to be ordinary, or a hotel tout who boards at the arrival stop to steer you to his hotel. Check recent reviews of the specific operator, keep valuables on your body rather than in the luggage hold, and ignore the arrival-stop touts the same way you ignore airport ones.

For women travelling alone on overnight sleeper buses, see the chapter for women travellers.

Domestic flights

Domestic flights are often cheap and save enormous time. Book directly with the airline or a well-known booking platform. Most issues are about baggage: Indian low-cost carriers have strict checked and cabin baggage limits, and fees at the airport are much higher than pre-paid baggage online. Weigh your bag before you go.

Airport security in India often requires you to remove electronics and power banks from your bag. Power banks must be in your cabin bag, not checked luggage.

Hiring a car and driver

For Rajasthan and the Golden Triangle (Delhi–Agra–Jaipur), many travellers hire a car with a driver for several days. It is comfortable and good value, and many drivers are excellent. The structure of the business,

however, includes commission.

The commission stops

How it works: Your driver is paid modestly, and much of his income comes from shops, restaurants and sometimes hotels that pay commission for bringing tourists. He may stop at a "very good" lunch place on the highway (where prices are three times normal), a carpet "cooperative", a marble "factory" in Agra, or a gem "workshop" in Jaipur. None of this is criminal, but it can eat hours of your trip and a lot of money.

Red flags: "Very good restaurant, my friend." Unplanned stops. A driver who is unusually keen on one particular shop.

Your move: Set rules on day one, kindly and clearly: no shopping stops, you choose where you eat. Put it in writing (a WhatsApp message to the operator is fine). Tip well at the end for a driver who respects this — that is the best way to make him happy without the shops.

SAY THIS

"Shopping nahi karni hai. Khana hum khud chunenge. Aapko achha tip denge." (We don't want to shop. We'll choose where we eat. We'll give you a good tip.)

What should be in the price?

Ask for an all-inclusive price that covers fuel, tolls, state taxes and permits, parking, the driver's food and accommodation allowance, and night charges. Ask what happens if you go over a daily kilometre limit. Pay a deposit and the balance at the end.



CHAPTER 4

City-by-City Scam Maps

Each city has its own personality, and its own scams. Here are the ones that matter on the main tourist circuit. I have kept the most detail for Varanasi, because that is my home and where I can tell you things no other guidebook will.

Delhi

Delhi is many travellers' first stop, and the arrival scams in Chapter 1 — the hotel-closed driver, the fake tourist office and the station tout — are the main Delhi dangers. A few more to know:

The "it's closed today" redirect

How it works: Near Connaught Place, India Gate or Jama Masjid, a friendly local asks where you are going and tells you the place is closed today — a holiday, a VIP visit, "only open for Indians today". He has a

much better suggestion, and an auto driver friend waiting. The route ends at a shop or a tourist office.

Red flags: Unasked information about closures. A ready-made alternative plan. An auto driver who just happens to be waiting.

Your move: Check opening times yourself (Google Maps is usually accurate, or ask your hotel) and go anyway. Monuments in India do have closing days — but you should learn about them from the official source, not a stranger.

SAY THIS

"Main khud dekh lunga." (I'll see for myself.)

The shoe-shine "dirt" trick

How it works: Something lands on your shoe — mud, a splash, something worse. A shoe-shine man happens to be right there and offers to clean it. Afterwards he demands a large amount, sometimes several hundred rupees. In some versions, an accomplice threw the dirt.

Red flags: Something lands on your shoe out of nowhere, and a shoe-shine man is standing right there.

Your move: Decline, walk to a café or your hotel and clean it yourself with a tissue. If you do want a shine, agree the price first (₹30–100 is plenty).

SAY THIS

"Nahi chahiye. Main khud saaf kar lunga." (I don't need it. I'll clean it myself.) Women say "kar lungi".

Old Delhi and Chandni Chowk

The lanes of Old Delhi are wonderful and mostly scam-free beyond pickpockets and inflated prices. At Jama Masjid, there is no general entry fee for visitors, but there is a fee for carrying a camera or phone camera; rules have changed over the years, so ask at the gate and pay only at the official desk with a receipt. Men may try to rent you a robe or charge for shoe-minding; a small amount for shoe-minding is normal (see the Temples chapter).

Agra

Agra exists, for most visitors, because of the Taj Mahal. It is spectacular, and the crowds and touts around it are intense.

Know the official price

The Taj Mahal ticket for foreign nationals is set by the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI). In 2026 it is around ₹1,100 for entry plus around ₹200 extra for entry into the main mausoleum, so roughly ₹1,300 in total; booking online through the official ASI ticketing portal is often slightly cheaper and lets you skip the ticket queue. The foreigner ticket typically includes shoe covers and a bottle of water. Citizens of SAARC and BIMSTEC countries pay much less. Check the current price before you go — and note that the **Taj Mahal is closed on Fridays**.

The fake guide

How it works: Men approach you at the car park, the electric shuttle drop-off or the ticket area, saying they are "official guides" and you are not allowed in without one, or that the ticket queue is two hours long but they can get you in fast. Some show laminated cards. Inside, the "tour" is short, and ends at a marble shop.

Red flags: Claims that a guide is mandatory (it is not). Claims of skip-the-line access that only he can provide. A price that is suspiciously low, or no price at all ("pay what you like").

Your move: You do not need a guide to enjoy the Taj. If you want one, hire a licensed guide through your hotel or the official tourism counters; licensed guides carry an identity card issued by the government tourism authorities, and you can ask to see it and photograph it. Agree the price, duration and "no shopping" before you start.

SAY THIS

"I have my ticket and I don't need a guide. Thank you."

The ticket and shuttle confusion

Vehicles cannot drive right up to the Taj; you will be dropped at a parking area and then take a battery-operated shuttle or walk the last stretch. Auto and cycle-rickshaw drivers sometimes claim the shuttle is "not running" and offer to take you for a high fee. Others say "this gate is closed, use the other gate" to lengthen the ride. Check your own map; the Taj has several gates (East, West and South), and the East Gate tends to be quieter.

The marble inlay "factory"

How it works: After the Taj, your driver or guide takes you to a workshop where a craftsman demonstrates *pietra dura* inlay — semi-precious stones set into white marble. You are told the craftsmen are "descendants of the original Taj artisans" and that this is a government-approved cooperative. The demonstration is real and fascinating. The table tops and plates are then priced at tens of thousands of rupees, and there may be an offer to ship it home.

Red flags: You did not ask to go there. Phrases like "descendant of Taj workers", "government approved", "no pressure, just look". Claims that the stones are all precious when the price does not match. Shipping offers.

Your move: Enjoy the demonstration if you want — it is a beautiful craft — but do not buy on the day of the visit. Compare prices at a fixed-price government emporium first. Real marble is cold to the touch and heavy; soapstone and resin fakes are lighter and softer. If you buy something large, read the shipping section in the Shopping chapter first.

SAY THIS

"Just looking today, thank you. I don't buy on the first day."

Jaipur and Rajasthan

Rajasthan is magnificent: forts, palaces, deserts, and some of the best craft traditions in the world. It is also home to the most elaborate, most expensive scam in this book.

The gem scam

I am going to explain this one in depth, because it costs travellers thousands of dollars, and it is designed so that intelligent people walk into it step by step.

How it works:

1. **The friendly meeting.** You meet a charming young man, often near a fort, a café or your guesthouse. He is well-dressed, educated, curious about your country. Sometimes he is introduced by a "fellow traveller" — another foreigner who appears to be backpacking, but is actually part of the operation. Over a day or two, he becomes your friend. You have chai with his family. You trust him.
2. **The business story.** He mentions that his family is in the gem or jewellery export business. Government export taxes on gems are very high, he explains, but there is a legal way around it: tourists are allowed to carry a certain value of gems out of India personally, duty free.

3. **The offer.** His family has a buyer in your country — a shop, a dealer — who will pay much more than the Indian price. If you carry a small parcel of gems home, the buyer will pay you, and you will make a big profit for helping. Sometimes he does not even ask you to pay anything at first. He just needs you to "sign as the exporter".
4. **The hook.** Then comes the twist: to prove you are a genuine buyer (for "customs" or "the bank"), you must buy the gems yourself, using your credit card. Don't worry — you will get the money back many times over when the buyer in your country pays you. Sometimes they show you letters, contracts, business cards, phone calls with "the buyer", even testimonials from previous travellers who "made thousands".
5. **The reality.** The gems are glass, or real stones of very low value. The buyer at home does not exist, or never answers. Your card payment has gone through, and the merchant claims you knowingly purchased goods.

Variations: You are asked to buy gems to "resell at a profit" yourself; you are told an Indian government rule allows tourists to export a certain value of jewellery without tax (the details are invented or twisted); or you are taken to a gem "factory" where you are told you are getting wholesale prices.

Red flags:

- Any business proposal from someone you met recently in India. Real businesses do not need tourists to carry their goods.
- Anything involving carrying goods across borders for someone else. Apart from losing money, you may also be breaking customs laws in India or at home.
- "Other travellers did this and made money" — especially if one of those travellers is right there helping to convince you.
- Being asked to pay with a credit card "just as a guarantee", with promises it will not be charged.
- Pressure to keep it secret, or to act before you leave the city.

Your move: Say no to any deal that involves you buying goods to sell abroad, carrying anything for anyone, or "guarantee" payments. This is not a negotiation. If you love gems and want to buy one for yourself, buy from a reputable shop with a certificate from a recognised gem testing laboratory, pay only what you would happily pay for a pretty stone with no resale value, and keep every receipt.

SAY THIS

*"I don't do business while travelling. Thank you for the chai."
Then leave.*

If you have already paid by card, contact your card issuer immediately (see the chapter on what to do if you are scammed). Act fast — chargeback windows are limited.

Other Rajasthan patterns

- **"Government" craft cooperatives and carpet showrooms** — the same commission structure as Agra's marble. Enjoy the demonstration, buy elsewhere, or buy only what you would happily pay for.
- **Fort and palace "guides"** at Amber Fort and elsewhere: licensed guides exist and are often excellent. Hire at the official counter or through your hotel, and agree price and duration.
- **Elephant rides** at Amber Fort have long been criticised by animal welfare groups. Many visitors now walk up or take a jeep instead.
- **Camel safaris in Jaisalmer and Pushkar** are often sold by the guesthouse you stay in. Get the inclusions in writing (food, water, blankets, number of nights, sharing or private), check recent reviews, and do not pay everything to a man in the street.
- **Pushkar's "Brahma passport"**: at Pushkar's lake, men hand you flowers, lead you to the water and guide you through a ritual, then demand a large donation for your family's prosperity. See the Temples chapter.

Varanasi

Here is my city. Varanasi is ancient and alive, overwhelming and holy, and it rewards the traveller who arrives prepared. The scams here are not violent; they are psychological. They feed on confusion — the maze of lanes, the rituals you do not understand yet, the sheer intensity of the riverfront. Here is the full map.

The boat price list

How it works: At Dashashwamedh and other busy ghats, boatmen quote foreigners ₹3,000 to ₹5,000 for a one-hour ride, sometimes showing a laminated "official rate card" they printed themselves.

The real prices (2026, approximate):

Ride	Fair price
Private hand-rowed boat, 2–4 people	₹800–1,500 per hour
Shared boat, per person	₹30–100 for a basic shared crossing or ride; organised shared sunrise or aarti rides can cost more
Evening aarti private boat (you wait on the water for the ceremony)	Higher than a daytime hour, because the boat is tied up for longer
Festival nights (such as Dev Deepawali in November)	Can be several times normal; book early

Red flags: A "rate card" that is laminated and handwritten-looking. A price that keeps changing. Someone other than the boatman doing the talking.

Your move: Agree three things before you step onto the boat: price, duration (in minutes, not "one ride"), and route. Pay at the end, not the start. Walk to a quieter ghat — Assi, or the ghats a few minutes north or south of Dashashwamedh — for calmer negotiation.

SAY THIS

"Ek ghanta, private boat, kitne ka?" (One hour, private boat, how much?) □ "Aath sau mein chalenge?" (Will you go for eight hundred?)

The middleman boatman

How it works: Someone walks with you to the river and "introduces" you to his boatman friend. The quote now includes the middleman's commission.

Red flags: Someone who walks with you to the river uninvited, calls the boatman "my friend", or does the talking on the boatman's behalf.

Your move: Walk down to the water yourself and talk directly to the person who will row your boat.

SAY THIS

"Main khud boat dhoondh lunga, shukriya." (I'll find a boat myself, thanks.)

The ghat "entry ticket"

How it works: A man with a receipt book, or in a jacket that looks semi-official, tells you a ticket is needed to enter the ghat.

Truth: The ghats are public and free. There is no ticket to walk on any ghat.

Red flags: A receipt book, a jacket that looks official, and a request for money at the top of the steps.

Your move: Smile and walk past.

SAY THIS

"Ghat free hai, bhaiya." (The ghat is free, brother.) Then keep walking.

The Manikarnika wood donation

This is the most aggressive and emotionally manipulative scam in Varanasi.

How it works: At Manikarnika, the main cremation ghat, a kind man — sometimes claiming to be a priest, a hospice worker, or a member of the families who tend the fires — offers to explain the cremation rituals for free. His explanations are partly true and genuinely moving. He takes you to a terrace or balcony "for a better view". Then he tells you about the poor and dying who cannot afford wood for a proper cremation, and shows you a ledger with other tourists' names and large "donations" — \$50, \$100, more. He asks you to buy wood by the kilo, at a price several times its real cost. If you hesitate, he may become emotional or angry, or say you have disrespected the dead.

Truth: The families performing cremations at Manikarnika arrange and pay for them themselves. No genuine priest or family will ask a tourist to buy wood. The money goes to the man who asked.

Red flags: An uninvited explanation. Being led upstairs or onto a platform. A ledger. Any request for money "for the dead".

Your move: Observe Manikarnika respectfully from the open steps or from a boat on the river. Do not photograph the cremations — it is deeply disrespectful to the grieving families, and you may be confronted. If someone starts explaining, say you are just observing, and move along the riverside path. Never follow anyone up a staircase there.

SAY THIS

"No thank you, I'm only observing." / "Bas dekh raha hoon." (I'm just watching.) Women would say "dekh rahi hoon."

The silk "factory"

How it works: An auto driver tells you the temple you want is closed for two hours, and offers to wait at a "government silk factory" nearby. Or a friendly guide shows you real weavers working on handlooms, then leads you to a showroom upstairs. Banarasi silk is a real, centuries-old craft and some of these demonstrations show genuine weaving — but the showroom prices are inflated to pay commission, and mixed or synthetic fabric may be sold as pure silk.

Red flags: "The temple is closed, let's wait at the factory." "Government silk." Tea offered before you have even looked at anything.

Your move: Decide where you will shop yourself. Visit a few shops, compare, and buy without a driver or guide present. See the Shopping chapter for authenticity checks.

SAY THIS

"Mandir chalo, factory nahi." (Take me to the temple, not the factory.)

The "English practice" student

How it works: A polite young man near Dashashwamedh or in the lanes just wants to practise his English and show you the "real, hidden Varanasi". The tour is good for twenty minutes, then turns into a visit to an uncle's shop, a cousin's guesthouse, or a request for money for his "studies".

Red flags: Fluent English from someone who says he needs practice. "Free" tour. Talk of an uncle's or cousin's shop.

Your move: In Varanasi, there is no free tour from a stranger. Thank him and continue alone, or hire a guide recommended by your hotel at an agreed price.

SAY THIS

"Your English is already very good! I'm happy walking alone, thank you."

The sadhu photo

How it works: A man dressed as a sadhu (Hindu ascetic), with ash, dreadlocks and saffron robes, poses for or invites a photo, then demands ₹500 or more.

Red flags: Someone in saffron who poses for you or beckons you over at a scenic spot near tourists.

Your move: If you want a photo with a sadhu, ask first and agree a price — ₹20–50 is a respectful amount. If you did not ask and someone poses uninvited, you owe nothing; walk on calmly. Always ask before photographing anyone in Varanasi, especially at bathing ghats.

SAY THIS

"Maine photo nahi maangi." (I didn't ask for a photo.)

"Hotel closed" in the old city

How it works: Taxis cannot enter the narrow lanes, so you are dropped at the edge of the old city. A "helper" offers to walk you to your guesthouse — and walks you to a different one, saying yours is closed or full.

Red flags: A stranger who knows your guesthouse "very well" and has bad news about it.

Your move: Message your guesthouse in advance and ask them to meet you at a named landmark. Most guesthouses near the ghats do this happily.

SAY THIS

"Mera guesthouse wala aa raha hai." (Someone from my guesthouse is coming.)

The aarti "VIP seat"

How it works: The evening Ganga Aarti at Dashashwamedh Ghat starts around sunset — roughly 6:00 pm in winter, closer to 6:45–7:00 pm in summer — and lasts about 45 minutes. Men offer "reserved VIP chairs" for several hundred rupees.

Red flags: "Official" or "VIP" seating. There are no official paid seats; chairs rented by local businesses are legitimate but entirely optional.

Your move: Arrive 45–60 minutes early for a good free spot on the steps, or watch from a boat with the price agreed in advance.

SAY THIS

"Main seedhi pe baithunga." (I'll sit on the steps.) Women say "baithungi".

Goa

Goa is relaxed, and its scams are relaxed too — mostly about transport, rentals and beach bills.

The scooter rental damage claim

How it works: You rent a scooter, return it, and the owner points to scratches or damage that were already there and demands payment, sometimes holding your passport as a "deposit".

Red flags: A request to keep your passport. No written agreement. An owner who does not want you to film the scooter.

Your move: Never leave your passport as a deposit; offer a cash deposit or a photocopy. Before you ride off, film a slow video of the whole scooter with the owner in frame, including existing scratches, the fuel level and the odometer. Get the price and the deposit in writing (a WhatsApp message counts).

Also: to ride legally in India as a foreigner, you need a valid licence from home plus an International Driving Permit that covers motorcycles. Police checkpoints in Goa are common, and fines for riding without the correct licence or without a helmet are real.

SAY THIS

*"Let's video the scooter together first." / "Passport nahi doonga."
(I won't give my passport.) Women say "doongi".*

The taxi price surprise

How it works: Goa taxis are often unmetered and expensive by Indian standards, and the fare named at the end can differ from what you thought you agreed.

Red flags: No price agreed before departure. "Night charge" or "return charge" announced on arrival.

Your move: Ask your hotel for the usual fare and agree it before you get in. Where app options or the state-backed taxi app work, use them as a benchmark.

SAY THIS

"Total kitna, pehle bataiye." (Tell me the total first.)

Beach shack bills and drink spiking

Most beach shacks are honest and great fun. Check the menu prices before ordering, especially for seafood sold "by weight" — ask the price per 100 grams and the weight of your fish before it is cooked. Keep an eye on your drink, do not accept drinks from strangers, and be cautious at very crowded parties. Avoid buying anything from strangers on the beach late at night; drug laws in India are strict and some "dealers" work with corrupt actors who then demand a payoff.

Mumbai

Mumbai is fast, friendly and less touristy than you might expect. Its scams are urban and opportunistic.

The baby-formula scam

How it works: A woman holding a baby approaches you, not asking for money but for milk powder or formula for the child. She leads you to a nearby shop. You buy a large tin at an inflated price. After you leave, she returns it to the shop and they split the money.

Red flags: A request not for money but for a specific, expensive item from one specific shop.

Your move: If you want to help, donate to an established charity instead. You can say no kindly.

SAY THIS

"Maaf kijiye." (Sorry / excuse me.) And walk on.

The "Bollywood extra" offer

How it works: Around Colaba, a man asks if you would like to appear in a Bollywood film as an extra. Sometimes this is a genuine (if long, hot and low-paid) day on set. Sometimes it involves an upfront "registration fee", or you are taken far from the city and paid much less than promised.

Red flags: An upfront fee. Vague details about the location, timings or pay.

Your move: Never pay to be an extra. If you are curious and it is free, go with a friend, tell your hotel where you are going, and agree the payment and return transport in advance.

SAY THIS

"No fee. If it's free, tell me the address and timings in writing."

Taxis and the Elephanta ferry

Mumbai's black-and-yellow taxis and autos are usually metered (autos operate in the suburbs, not in South Mumbai). Insist on the meter, or use an app. For the Elephanta Caves ferry from the Gateway of India, buy tickets at the official ticket counters by the jetty rather than from people walking around the plaza.

Rishikesh and Haridwar

Rishikesh is the yoga capital of the world and Haridwar is one of Hinduism's holiest cities. Both are peaceful places where the scams wear robes.

The puja donation at the river

How it works: At Har Ki Pauri in Haridwar, or the ghats of Rishikesh, a man in priestly dress offers to perform a blessing for you and your family — he ties a red thread on your wrist, puts a tilak mark on your forehead,

asks your family members' names, and recites a prayer. At the end he asks for a donation of ₹1,000 or ₹2,000 or more, or names a "minimum" for the ritual. Some say the donation must be in proportion to your wealth for the blessing to work.

Red flags: A thread tied or tilak applied before you agreed. Asking for your family's names. A "minimum" donation.

Your move: If you do not want a puja, decline before it starts — keep your hands to yourself and step back. If you do want one, agree a donation amount before anything begins. ₹50–200 is a respectful offering for a simple blessing. The Temples chapter has more.

SAY THIS

"Pehle batao, kitna dakshina?" (Tell me first, how much is the offering?)

The fake guru and the yoga "certificate"

Rishikesh is full of genuine teachers and also full of people who discovered that "guru" is a profitable job title. Choose yoga schools and teacher trainings based on detailed, recent reviews, and be cautious of any teacher who asks for money for "special initiations", or who touches students in ways that make them uncomfortable. Many accredited teacher trainings are registered with international yoga bodies; check the registration claim yourself rather than trusting a certificate on the wall.

Rafting

White-water rafting near Rishikesh is popular and seasonal. Choose operators who give you a proper helmet and life jacket, a safety briefing, and a guide with rescue training. Licensing and season dates for rafting are regulated by the state; book through your guesthouse or an operator with strong recent reviews rather than a street tout offering the cheapest price.

Kerala

Kerala is one of India's most relaxed states for travellers, and the scams are mostly about bookings and quality.

The houseboat switch

How it works: You book a backwater houseboat (in Alappuzha/Alleppey or Kumarakom) and on arrival you are given a smaller, older boat than the photos, or one that does not have the AC hours, meals or route you were promised. Touts at the bus and train stations in Alleppey may also sell houseboats at "special prices", then deliver something very different.

Red flags: Station or bus-stand touts with "special prices". Photos only, no written inclusions. Full payment demanded upfront.

Your move: Book with an operator you can verify through recent reviews or your hotel. Get in writing: boat size, number of bedrooms, AC hours (houseboats often only run AC at night), meals included, cruising hours, and the exact check-in and check-out times. Inspect the boat before you pay the balance. Note that houseboats generally stop cruising and moor in the evening — that is normal, not a scam.

SAY THIS

"Sab kuch likh ke dijiye." (Give me everything in writing.)

Ayurveda "treatments"

Kerala is the home of Ayurveda, and there are excellent, medically supervised Ayurvedic centres. There are also massage shops calling themselves "Ayurvedic hospitals". For anything beyond a relaxing massage, choose a centre with qualified practitioners, read recent reviews, and do not stop or change any medicine from your own doctor on an Ayurvedic practitioner's advice.

Kochi and Munnar shop stops

How it works: In Fort Kochi, autos offer cheap sightseeing loops that end at spice and handicraft shops. In Munnar, tea and spice "factory" tours can finish in an expensive showroom.

Red flags: A sightseeing price that seems too cheap. "Just look, no buy."

Your move: Agree the route in advance and buy spices at busy local markets or shops where locals buy.

SAY THIS

"Sirf sightseeing, shopping nahi." (Only sightseeing, no shopping.)



CHAPTER 5

Temples and Religious Scams

Temples, ghats, mosques and gurdwaras are among the most beautiful places you will visit in India. They are also where many travellers feel most unsure of themselves — you do not know the customs, you do not want to offend anyone, and that uncertainty is exactly what religious scams exploit.

Here is the principle that protects you: **genuine religious donation in India is voluntary, private, and never pressured.** Hindu temples have donation boxes (*daan peti*) and official counters that issue receipts. Gurdwaras (Sikh temples) feed everyone for free in the langar, and no one will ask you for money. If someone is naming a price, holding a ledger, or getting upset at the size of your offering, you are not dealing with religion. You are dealing with business.

The fake priest blessing

How it works: At a temple entrance or a riverside ghat, a man in religious dress smiles, takes your hand, ties a red-and-yellow thread (*kalawa* or *mauli*) around your wrist, presses a tilak on your forehead, and starts chanting. He asks your name, your parents' names, your country. At the end, he asks for a donation — often naming a large figure, or saying "people from your country give ₹1,000". If you offer ₹50, he is offended.

Red flags: You were touched or blessed before you agreed to anything. A named "minimum". References to what other foreigners pay. Anger at a small offering.

Your move: If you do not want a blessing, keep your hands close to your body and step away before anything is tied or applied. If something is already done, offer a small amount you consider fair (₹20–50) and leave calmly. You are not obliged to pay more.

SAY THIS

"Nahi, dhanyavaad." (No, thank you.) If it's already done: "Bas itna hi." (Only this much.) — and hand over a small note.

The puja package

How it works: At big pilgrimage sites, "pandas" (hereditary temple priests) or self-appointed guides offer to perform a special puja for your family's health, wealth or ancestors. Some pandas are genuine and serve pilgrims respectfully; others are touts. The ritual takes place, and the donation demanded at the end is far more than suggested at the start, with extra costs for flowers, coconuts, cloth and "the priest's fee".

Red flags: Prices for materials added one by one during the ritual. No total agreed at the start.

Your move: If you genuinely want a puja, arrange it through your hotel or a trusted local, and agree the total amount — including all materials — before anything starts. Write it down.

SAY THIS

"Sab milake total kitna?" (How much is the total, everything included?)

"VIP darshan" and queue-jumping

How it works: At popular temples with long queues, men offer to get you in faster through a side entrance for a fee.

Truth: Some major temples do sell official special-entry or quick-darshan tickets, at an official counter, with a receipt. Others have no such system at all. A man in the street offering a shortcut is not the official system.

Red flags: A man in the street, not an official counter. No receipt. A side door.

Your move: Ask at the temple office or official counter. If there is no official fast-track, stand in line like everyone else — it is part of the experience.

SAY THIS

"Main line mein lagunga." (I'll stand in the queue.) Women say "lagungi".

Shoe-minding

At most Hindu temples, Sikh gurdwaras and mosques, you remove your shoes before entering. Many temples have a free official shoe stand; at others, a man or a stall minds shoes for a small fee. ₹10–20 per pair is normal at many places; some free stands accept small tips. The "scam"

version is a man who asks ₹100 or more, or who appears after you come out and demands payment for a stand you did not use.

Red flags: No price board. A stall that is also a shop. A minder who appears only when you come out.

Your move: Ask the price before handing over your shoes. Carry a cloth bag so you can keep your shoes with you where that is allowed.

SAY THIS

"Joote rakhne ka kitna?" (How much to keep the shoes?)

Flower and offering sellers

How it works: Outside temples, sellers offer flowers, sweets and coconuts to take inside — a real and lovely tradition. Some quote tourists inflated prices, or insist you leave your shoes at their stall so you then "must" buy.

Red flags: "Leave your shoes here, free." No price mentioned until after you have taken the plate.

Your move: Agree the price first. Small offering plates or flower cones typically cost ₹20–100.

SAY THIS

"Pehle daam bataiye." (Tell me the price first.)

The lake ritual at Pushkar

At Pushkar's sacred lake in Rajasthan, men hand visitors a flower and invite them to the water for a "free" prayer. They lead you through a ritual on the steps, then demand a large donation for your family, sometimes physically standing between you and the exit. Some offer a red thread called a "Pushkar passport" that supposedly protects you from

being asked again.

Red flags: A flower pushed into your hand. Being led down to the water. Someone standing between you and the exit.

Your move: Do not accept a flower from anyone at the ghats. If one is pushed into your hand, put it down on the step and walk away. If you want to do a puja, agree a donation first.

SAY THIS

"Nahi chahiye, shukriya." Put the flower down and walk on.

Being a respectful visitor

Avoiding scams is only half the job. A few things will win you real respect from local people:

- Remove your shoes where others do, and do not point your feet at shrines or people.
- Cover shoulders and knees at religious sites; at gurdwaras and some mosques, cover your head (scarves are often provided).
- Ask before photographing. Many temples ban photography inside; some ban phones entirely and provide lockers.
- Some temples do not allow non-Hindus into the inner sanctum. Accept this graciously — it is not a scam.
- If you wish to give, use the official donation box or counter, and ask for a receipt.



CHAPTER 6

Shopping

Shopping in India is a joy — silk, cotton, pashmina, block prints, brass, wood, spices, tea, jewellery — but it is also where the biggest single overpayments happen. The trick is knowing the difference between a commission shop and a fair one, and knowing how to check what you are buying.

The commission economy, explained

Many tourist shops in India pay commission to the drivers, guides, rickshaw-wallas and hotel staff who bring them customers. Rates can be very high — sometimes 20–50% of what you spend. That commission is built into the price, so when someone brings you to a shop, you are paying for the person who brought you.

This is why the rule is simple: **never shop where you were taken. Shop where you chose to go.**

The "government emporium" impostor

How it works: A driver tells you he is taking you to a "government emporium" or "government-approved shop" with fixed fair prices. The shop has an official-sounding name, perhaps a sign with an emblem, and certificates on the wall. It is a private shop.

Truth: Genuine government-run emporiums exist — for example the Central Cottage Industries Emporium on Janpath in New Delhi, and the state government emporiums along Baba Kharak Singh Marg near Connaught Place. Many states also run their own handicraft emporiums in their own cities. They have printed, fixed price tags, accept cards and issue receipts. They do not need drivers to recruit customers.

Red flags: You were taken there. "Government approved" rather than government run. No printed price tags.

Your move: Check the exact name and location yourself on a map and in recent reviews before going. If the driver chose the shop, it is probably not what he says.

SAY THIS

"I'll choose the shop myself, thank you."

Authenticity checks

These are simple tests that help. None of them is perfect. For expensive purchases, buy from established shops that will issue a proper invoice describing the material.

Silk (including Banarasi silk)

- **The burn test** is the classic: a thread of real silk burns slowly, smells like burning hair, and leaves a crushable ash; synthetics melt into a hard bead and smell like plastic. Ask the shopkeeper to do it on a loose thread from the item. A confident shopkeeper will.

- **Look at the reverse** of handwoven brocade. Handloom pieces have small irregularities and floating threads on the back; machine-made pieces look perfectly uniform.
- **Silk Mark:** India's Silk Mark label is a voluntary quality mark for pure silk. Its presence is a good sign; its absence does not prove a fake.
- **Price sense:** genuine handwoven Banarasi silk saris take days to weeks of work and cost accordingly. A "pure handloom silk sari" for a few hundred rupees is not.

Pashmina and cashmere

- Genuine pashmina is very soft, light and warm, and slightly irregular in texture. Pure pashmina is usually not shiny.
- "Pashmina" is used loosely in markets to mean any soft shawl. Many are wool, acrylic or blends — which can be lovely, but should be priced accordingly.
- Shahtoosh (from the endangered Tibetan antelope) is illegal to sell or buy. If someone offers you a "ring shawl" made of shahtoosh, walk away.

Gems and jewellery

- Buy gems only for their beauty, never as an investment. Resale value is almost always far below what you paid.
- For any significant stone, ask for a certificate from a recognised independent gem testing laboratory, and confirm the certificate's number with the laboratory itself.
- Gold jewellery in India is generally hallmarked under the Bureau of Indian Standards (BIS) system. Look for the hallmark and ask for an invoice stating the purity and weight.
- See the Jaipur gem scam in Chapter 4. Never buy gems to resell or carry for anyone.

Antiques

India restricts the export of antiques (generally items over 100 years old) without official permission. Most "antiques" sold to tourists are reproductions. If something is described as a genuine antique, that is either not true or a legal problem.

Shipping scams

How it works: You buy a carpet, a marble table top or a stack of textiles, and the shop offers to ship it home for you. Sometimes the parcel never arrives. Sometimes it arrives with cheaper goods inside than the ones you picked. Sometimes you are later asked for extra "customs" or "shipping" fees.

Red flags: Pressure to buy large items that "must be shipped". Shops that will not let you see the exact item being packed. Cash-only payment for shipped goods.

Your move: Wherever possible, carry purchases yourself. If you must ship:

1. Watch the item being packed, and sign or mark the inside of the packaging or the item itself (a photo of you with the item and your signature on a label inside helps).
2. Get a written invoice describing the item exactly — size, material, colour, price — and the shipping method, cost and expected delivery date.
3. Pay by credit card, which gives you the best chance of a chargeback if the goods never arrive.
4. Ask for a tracking number from a known courier or postal service, not just the shop's word.
5. Be aware that your home country may charge import duty and taxes on arrival.



CHAPTER 7

Accommodation and Bookings

Most accommodation in India is booked online now, which has removed many old scams but created a few new ones.

The fake listing

How it works: You find a beautiful guesthouse on social media, a classified site or a website you have never heard of. You pay by bank transfer or a payment link. On arrival, the property does not exist, or has never heard of you.

Red flags: Prices far below similar places. Payment only by bank transfer, gift cards or crypto. A property with no reviews on major platforms.

Your move: Book through well-known platforms that hold your payment and offer customer support, or directly with properties you can verify through reviews on more than one platform. Be very cautious of

anyone who asks you to move payment off a booking platform, or to pay by wire transfer, gift cards or cryptocurrency.

SAY THIS

"I'll only pay through the booking platform."

The "pay us on WhatsApp" message

How it works: After you book on a platform, you receive a message — sometimes even inside the platform's messaging system, if a hotel account has been compromised — asking you to confirm your booking by paying through a link or else it will be cancelled.

Red flags: Threats of cancellation. A payment link. A new account number. Urgency.

Your move: Do not pay through links in messages. Log into the platform's app directly and check your booking status there. If in doubt, call the property using the number listed on the platform's own page.

SAY THIS

"I'll check in the app and call the number listed there."

The hotel switch on arrival

How it works: You arrive and the hotel says your room is "not available" — overbooked, maintenance problem — and offers you a room at a "sister property", which turns out to be worse.

Red flags: "Sister property" mentioned before you have seen any room. Reluctance to show you the new room.

Your move: Overbookings do happen. A good hotel will "walk" you to an equal or better property at its cost. Before you agree, ask to see the new room or a photo, and ask the booking platform's support to record

the change. Do not pay extra for a downgrade.

SAY THIS

"Show me the new room first, please. I won't pay extra for this."

The extra charges at checkout

Common surprise charges: "AC charges", "hot water charges", "luggage storage", "Wi-Fi", "early check-in", or a GST (tax) line that was not mentioned. Some of these are legitimate if they were disclosed. Many are not.

Red flags: Charges that were never mentioned at booking or check-in. Taxes added on top of a price shown as "including taxes".

Your move: At check-in, ask: "Is this the full price, including all taxes? Are there any extra charges?" Take a screenshot of your booking confirmation showing the total. At checkout, compare the bill to it.

SAY THIS

"Booking mein sab included tha." (Everything was included in the booking.)

Guesthouse tour desks

Many guesthouses sell tours, transport and train tickets. Some are fair and convenient. Some add large markups. Compare one or two other options before you book anything expensive from the front desk, and ask for an itemised price.

LOCAL TIP

In Varanasi especially, a small, family-run guesthouse near the ghats is often the best scam shield you can buy. The family will tell you real prices, send someone to meet you, and warn you about the man on the corner — because your good review matters to them more than his commission.



CHAPTER 8

Digital Scams, SIM Cards and Visas

India is one of the most digital countries on earth, and digital scams have grown with it. Most of these can be avoided with one rule: **only use official websites and official apps, and never share a one-time password (OTP) with anyone.**

The e-visa: use only the official site

The official Indian e-visa website is **indianvisaonline.gov.in**. The Government of India and its embassies have repeatedly warned about fake e-visa websites that charge extra "processing" fees, sell visas that do not exist, or collect your passport data. The government does not appoint agents to submit e-visa applications for you.

The fake e-visa site

How it works: You search "India e-visa" and click a top result. The site looks official, with flags and emblems. You pay a fee that is two to five times the real one. In the best case, the site simply applies on your behalf through the official site and keeps the difference. In the worst case, you get nothing, or your data is misused.

Red flags: A web address that is not indianvisaonline.gov.in. "Express" or "guaranteed" processing for an extra fee. A fee much higher than the official fee schedule. Sponsored ads at the top of search results.

Your move: Type indianvisaonline.gov.in directly into your browser. Check the official fee for your nationality on that site. Apply well before your trip.

SAY THIS

No words needed — just type indianvisaonline.gov.in yourself.

Getting a SIM card properly

A local SIM makes everything easier: maps, app cabs, UPI, booking confirmations and staying in touch. Foreign visitors can buy a prepaid SIM with their passport and visa.

How to do it:

1. **At the airport:** At major international airports such as Delhi and Mumbai, a telecom operator kiosk in the arrivals area has typically sold tourist SIMs. Prices are usually higher than in town, but it is convenient.
2. **In town:** Go to an official operator store (not a small corner shop) with your passport, visa, a passport photo (sometimes required) and your hotel address. Ask for a tourist or prepaid plan.

3. **Activation:** Expect activation to take anywhere from a couple of hours up to about a day, sometimes involving a verification call.
4. **eSIM:** International travel eSIMs bought online before departure also work in India and are simple to set up, though they usually give you data only, not an Indian phone number. An Indian number is useful for receiving OTPs from Indian apps and services.

The SIM-card shortcut scam

How it works: Someone offers to "register a SIM in his name" for you, or sells you a pre-activated SIM with no paperwork. It may work for a few days, then be disconnected. Worse, a SIM in someone else's name can be used for fraud traced back to "your" number, and SIM registration rules in India are strict.

Red flags: No passport needed. A SIM "already activated" in someone else's name. A street seller instead of an official store.

Your move: Only buy from official operator stores or airport kiosks, with your own passport.

SAY THIS

*"Official store se hi lunga." (I'll only buy from an official store.)
Women say "lungi".*

OTP and phone scams

The OTP request

How it works: Someone — a "hotel", "bank", "delivery company", "IRCTC support" or a person who has sent you money "by mistake" — calls or messages asking you to read out a code that has just arrived by SMS. That code is a one-time password authorising a payment or a change to your account.

Red flags: Any request to read out a code. Urgency. A caller claiming to be from a bank, app or hotel.

Your move: Never share an OTP with anyone, for any reason. No genuine bank, app or company will ask you for it.

SAY THIS

"I never share OTPs." Then hang up.

The fake customer-care number

How it works: You search online for "IRCTC customer care" or "airline refund number" and call the first number you see. It belongs to a scammer, who asks you to install a "support" app (a remote-access tool) or to pay a small fee to process your refund.

Red flags: A number found through a search result or a social-media comment. A request to install an app or pay a "processing fee".

Your move: Only use contact numbers listed in the official app or on the official website. Never install an app because a caller asks you to.

SAY THIS

"I'll call the number in the official app." Then hang up.

Fake apps and fake payment screenshots

- Download apps only from the official Apple App Store or Google Play Store, and check the developer name.
- If someone shows you a screenshot "proving" they paid you, check your own app or bank. Fake payment screenshots are a common trick in shops and guesthouses.
- When paying by QR code, check that the name that appears on your screen matches the shop or person you intend to pay before you confirm.

WhatsApp scams

- **"Hi, this is your hotel / guide, please pay the balance to this new account."** Check by calling the number you already had.
- **Job or investment offers** — "earn money by liking videos" or "rating hotels". These are scams, everywhere in the world.
- **The "wrong number" friendship** that turns into a romance or crypto opportunity. Block.
- **Messages claiming to be the police**, saying a parcel in your name contains illegal items and you must pay to avoid arrest. Indian police do not arrest people over video calls or demand payment by transfer. Hang up and, if worried, contact your embassy or the local police station in person.

Public Wi-Fi and phone security

Use a passcode and biometrics on your phone, turn on "Find My" or the equivalent, and avoid logging into banking on open public Wi-Fi. Keep a photo of your passport and visa in secure cloud storage, and a paper copy separate from the original.



CHAPTER 9

For Women Travellers

Thousands of women travel India every year, alone and in groups, and have extraordinary trips. It is also true that women — especially foreign women — face unwanted attention, staring and sometimes harassment. I have sisters and cousins who navigate this every day. This chapter is the advice they and the women travellers I know would give you: practical, not fearful.

Before you go

- **Book your first nights at well-reviewed places** where other women have written reviews mentioning safety. Read those reviews specifically.
- **Plan arrivals in daylight** where you can. If you land late, book a hotel pickup.

- **Share your itinerary** with someone at home and set up live location sharing on your phone.
- **Save emergency numbers:** 112 (all emergencies across India), and your embassy's number. Many states also run women's helplines such as 1091 and 181. The government's 112 India app has an SOS feature; consider installing it.

Clothing and attention

What you wear does not cause harassment, and no one deserves it. But in practice, dressing in line with local norms reduces staring and gives you more control over the attention you receive. Loose clothes that cover shoulders and knees work almost everywhere; a light scarf is useful for temples, sun and dust. In Goa's beach areas and parts of Mumbai, norms are more relaxed. In small towns and religious cities like Varanasi, Haridwar and Pushkar, they are more conservative.

On the street

- **Walk with purpose.** Look like you know where you are going, even if you are checking the map in a café afterwards.
- **You do not owe anyone conversation.** Men who ask "Which country? Married? Where is your husband?" are often just curious, but you can end any conversation with "Nahi, shukriya" and keep walking.
- **Selfie requests** are constant in some places. You can say no. Groups of young men asking for selfies is when to be firmest.
- **Groping in crowds** happens, particularly at festivals and very crowded places. Holi in particular can get out of hand in some areas; if you want to experience it, do so with a group, at a hotel or organised event, and avoid drinking bhang (a cannabis drink often served at Holi).

- **If someone touches you**, make it loud and public. Indian bystanders — especially women — very often step in. A loud "Kya kar rahe ho?" (What are you doing?) draws attention immediately.

SAY THIS

"Peechhe hato!" (Get back!) / "Mujhe pareshaan mat karo."
(Don't bother me.) Said loudly, in public, it works.

Transport

- **App cabs** are generally the safest option at night: the trip is recorded, and you can share it. Check the plate and driver photo before getting in, sit in the back, and keep the route visible on your own map.
- **Delhi Metro and Mumbai local trains** have women-only coaches (usually the first coach in the direction of travel on the Delhi Metro, clearly marked). Use them, especially at rush hour.
- **On overnight trains**, AC classes (1A, 2A, 3A) are better for women travelling alone. Choose an upper berth if you can — it gives you more privacy and keeps your bag close. Indian Railways also has a ladies' quota on many trains for women travelling alone or with children.
- **Avoid overnight sleeper buses** if travelling alone for the first time; if you take one, choose a lower berth near the front (closer to the driver and cabin crew) and use a reputable operator.

Accommodation

- Check the door lock and the window locks. A rubber door wedge from home is a cheap extra layer.
- Do not tell strangers your room number or which hotel you are in.
- Be wary of staff who knock repeatedly with unnecessary "services". You can refuse housekeeping and keep the "do not disturb" sign up.

Guides, gurus and "friendships"

Be cautious with male guides, yoga teachers, massage therapists and "spiritual" teachers who want to meet you alone, especially if they suggest private sessions, unusual "healing" touch, or gradually move a professional relationship towards personal intimacy. In Rishikesh and Goa particularly, recommendations from other women travellers are worth more than anything on a poster.

Drink spiking is rare but real in party areas. Watch your drink, and do not accept open drinks from strangers.

LOCAL TIP

Indian women are your best allies. If you feel uncomfortable on a train, in a queue or on a bus, move to sit or stand near a family or a group of women. Ask an aunty for directions instead of a young man. You will be amazed how quickly you are adopted.



CHAPTER 10

Health and Food Safety

I am not a doctor, and this chapter is not medical advice. Before your trip, **see your doctor or a travel clinic, ideally six to eight weeks before departure**, to discuss vaccinations, malaria risk for your route, and medicines to carry. What follows is the practical, everyday side of staying well.

Delhi belly: prevention

Traveller's diarrhoea is the most common health problem visitors face. It is usually short and mild, but it can wreck two or three days of your trip. Prevention is mostly about water and hands.

- **Drink sealed bottled water or properly filtered water.** Check that the seal on bottled water is intact; refilled bottles are an old trick. Many hotels and cafés have reverse-osmosis (RO) filters and will refill your own bottle — a good, low-plastic option.

- **Avoid tap water**, including for brushing your teeth if your stomach is sensitive.
- **Ice** in upscale restaurants and hotels is usually made from purified water; at street stalls, skip it.
- **Wash or sanitise your hands** before eating, every time. Carry hand sanitiser.
- **Ease in.** Give your stomach a few days before you go all-in on street food.

Street food rules

Street food is one of the great joys of India, and you do not have to miss it. Follow the locals' instincts:

1. **Choose busy stalls**, especially ones busy with local families. High turnover means fresh food.
2. **Eat things cooked hot in front of you** — fresh samosas, kachoris, dosas, tikkis straight from the pan.
3. **Be careful with things that are raw or washed in local water**: cut fruit, salads, chutneys that have been sitting out, and pani puri (whose water is the whole point, but is also the risk).
4. **Dairy**: lassi and curd from busy, well-known shops are usually fine; avoid dairy that has been sitting in the heat.
5. **Meat and seafood** carry more risk; eat them at busy, reputable places, and less in the hottest months.

If you do get sick

For mild diarrhoea, rest and keep drinking fluids. Oral rehydration salts (ORS) are sold cheaply in every Indian pharmacy (look for the MRP on the packet). Seek medical care promptly if you have a high fever, blood in your stool, severe pain, signs of dehydration, or symptoms lasting more than a couple of days — and always follow advice from your own doctor

or travel clinic about medicines.

Private hospitals in major cities offer good care, often with English-speaking doctors. Your hotel can recommend one. Travel insurance that covers medical care and evacuation is essential.

Other health points to discuss with a professional

- **Mosquito-borne illnesses**, including dengue and, in some regions, malaria, are present. Use insect repellent, especially at dawn and dusk and during and after the monsoon.
- **Rabies**: street dogs and monkeys are common, particularly around temples. Do not touch or feed animals. If you are bitten or scratched, wash the wound thoroughly and seek medical care the same day. Ask your travel clinic whether pre-exposure vaccination makes sense for you.
- **Air quality** in North India, especially Delhi, can be very poor in late autumn and winter. If you have asthma or heart or lung conditions, check air quality forecasts and talk to your doctor.
- **Heat**: from roughly April to June, northern plains temperatures can be extreme. Plan sightseeing for early morning and evening, drink plenty of fluids, and rest in the afternoon.

The pharmacy scam

Pharmacies (chemists) are everywhere and very useful. Packaged medicines carry an MRP — never pay more than what is printed. Be cautious of pharmacies near tourist hotspots that push expensive "special" remedies, and of anyone recommending antibiotics or strong medicines without a doctor's assessment.



CHAPTER 11

The Scripts

These are the phrases I would teach a friend arriving in India for the first time. You do not need perfect pronunciation. Even a few words of Hindi change the tone of an interaction completely — the person in front of you instantly understands that you are not totally new, and the "tourist price" often drops on the spot.

Hindi is widely understood across North India, and in tourist areas elsewhere. In the South (Kerala, for example), English often works better than Hindi; use the English versions there.

A note on grammar: a few Hindi verbs change with the speaker's gender. Where it matters I give both: the first is what a man says, the second what a woman says.

Saying no

English	Hindi (romanised)	Meaning / when to use
No thank you, I'm fine.	Nahi, shukriya.	The all-purpose polite no
I don't want it.	Nahi chahiye.	For touts, sellers, unwanted help
I really don't want it.	Bilkul nahi chahiye.	When the first no didn't work
Leave it / never mind.	Rehne dijiye.	Ending a negotiation politely
Please don't follow me.	Mere peechhe mat aaiye.	Firm, clear
Go away.	Jaao. / Chalo, jaao.	Blunt; use only if needed
I'm just looking.	Bas dekh raha hoon / rahi hoon.	In shops, at ghats
I don't need a guide.	Guide nahi chahiye.	At monuments
I already have a booking.	Booking ho chuki hai.	For hotel and taxi touts

Asking prices and negotiating

English	Hindi (romanised)	Meaning / when to use
How much is it?	Kitne ka hai?	Prices of things
How much to [place]?	[Place] tak kitna?	Autos, rickshaws
That's too much.	Bahut zyada hai.	Your first reaction to any quote
Tell me the right price.	Sahi daam bataiye.	Signals you know the game
Final price?	Last kitna?	Asking for their best

English	Hindi (romanised)	Meaning / when to use
I'll give [100].	Main [sau] doonga / doongi.	Your counter-offer
OK, done.	Theek hai, pakka.	Agreeing a price
Total, for both of us.	Total, dono ke liye.	Avoiding per-person tricks
Give it at MRP.	MRP pe dijiye.	Packaged goods
I need change.	Change chahiye. / Khulle chahiye.	When a seller "has no change"
The rest of the money?	Baaki paise?	When change is short

Transport

English	Hindi (romanised)	Meaning / when to use
Go by the meter.	Meter se chalo.	Autos and taxis
Go straight to [place].	Seedha [place] chalo.	Prevents detours
No shops.	Koi dukaan nahi.	Before the ride starts
Stop here.	Yahan rokiye.	Getting out
Slowly, please.	Dheere chaliye.	Fast drivers
Go to this address.	Is address pe chalo.	Showing your map
Payment through the app.	App se payment hoga.	App cabs asking for cash

At the river, temples and shops

English	Hindi (romanised)	Meaning / when to use
One hour, private boat, how much?	Ek ghanta, private boat, kitne ka?	Varanasi ghats

English	Hindi (romanised)	Meaning / when to use
Pay at the end.	Paise baad mein.	Boats, guides
No stops, only the river.	Koi stop nahi, sirf ghat.	Before boarding
No photos?	Photo mana hai?	Asking if photos are allowed
May I take a photo?	Photo le sakta hoon / sakti hoon?	Always ask first
How much for the shoes?	Joote rakhne ka kitna?	Shoe-minding
Give me a receipt.	Receipt dijiye.	Fines, donations, purchases

Help and emergencies

English	Hindi (romanised)	Meaning / when to use
Help!	Bachao!	Emergency
Call the police.	Police ko bulao.	Emergency
Where is the police station?	Thana kahaan hai?	Reporting a problem
I need a doctor.	Mujhe doctor chahiye.	Illness, injury
Get back!	Peechhe hato!	Harassment; say it loudly
What are you doing?	Kya kar rahe ho?	Harassment; draws attention
Show me your ID.	Apna ID dikhaiye.	Fake officials, fake checkers

Kindness phrases (use these the most)

English	Hindi (romanised)
Hello / greetings	Namaste

English	Hindi (romanised)
Thank you	Dhanyavaad / Shukriya
Very good / delicious	Bahut achha / Bahut badhiya
Brother / sister (friendly address)	Bhaiya / Didi
Uncle / aunty (respectful address for elders)	Uncle-ji / Aunty-ji
Excuse me / sorry	Maaf kijiye

LOCAL TIP

Call your auto driver "bhaiya" (brother) and the woman selling flowers "didi" (sister). It is how locals speak. It is warm, it is respectful, and it changes the price more than you would believe.



CHAPTER 12

The Price Tables

Every price here is **approximate for 2026 — verify locally**. Prices vary by city, season, time of day and how far you are from a famous monument. Use these as a fair-price compass: if a quote is within or near the range, accept it gracefully; if it is double or triple, you have room to negotiate or walk.

Getting around

Item	Fair range (Rs)	Notes
Delhi airport to central Delhi, prepaid taxi	500–900	More at night and for bigger cars
Varanasi airport to city, prepaid taxi	800–1,000	Final stretch on foot into the old city

Item	Fair range (Rs)	Notes
Short auto ride (2–3 km) in North Indian cities	80–200	Check the app fare as a benchmark
Longer auto ride (5–8 km)	200–400	More in Delhi, Mumbai and Goa
Short cycle rickshaw ride (1–2 km)	50–150	Pay more in heat or with luggage
Car with driver, per day (Golden Triangle, sedan)	2,500–4,500	Ask what is included; varies by distance
Station porter, couple of bags	100–300	Agree before lifting
Scooter rental per day (Goa)	300–600	Season dependent; deposit extra

Food and drink

Item	Fair range (Rs)	Notes
Cup of chai at a street stall	10–30	More in cafés
Bottled water (1 litre)	MRP, usually ~20	Never pay above MRP
Street snack (samosa, kachori)	15–50	Per piece or plate
Simple thali at a local restaurant	100–300	Unlimited refills at many places
Meal at a mid-range tourist restaurant	400–1,000 per person	More in Goa, Mumbai, upscale areas
Lassi	40–120	More at famous shops

Varanasi specials

Item	Fair range (Rs)	Notes
Private hand-rowed boat, 2–4 people	800–1,500 per hour	Agree price, duration, route first
Shared boat, per person	30–100	Organised shared tours cost more
Entry to any ghat	Free	There is no ghat ticket
Sadhu photo	20–50	Only if you asked first
Diya (floating lamp) offering	10–30	Lovely tradition after aarti
Shoe-minding at a temple	10–20	Many temples are free
Simple blessing / puja offering	50–200	Agree before it starts

Sights and services

Item	Fair range (Rs)	Notes
Taj Mahal, foreigners (incl. mausoleum)	About 1,300	Official ASI price; closed Fridays; verify online
Licensed guide, half day	1,000–2,500	Varies by city and language
Tourist SIM card with a month of data	300–1,000	Airports often charge more
Laundry (per item, guesthouse)	20–60	Often cheaper by weight
Shoe shine	30–100	Agree first



CHAPTER 13

If You Do Get Scammed

Even careful travellers get caught sometimes. I have been overcharged in my own city. If it happens to you, the most important thing is to stay safe, act quickly where money can be recovered, and not let one bad experience colour the rest of your trip.

First: safety, then money

If you feel threatened, stop arguing. No amount of money is worth an escalating confrontation. Pay if you must, get to a safe, busy place, and deal with it afterwards. Your safety is the only thing that cannot be refunded.

Key numbers (save these now)

Service	Number	Notes
All emergencies (police, fire, ambulance)	112	Works nationwide; also via the 112 India app
India Tourism helpline	1363 or 1800-11-1363	Toll-free, 24/7, multiple languages; verify before travel
Cyber crime and online fraud	1930	Also report online at cybercrime.gov.in
Women's helplines (many states)	1091 / 181	Availability varies by state
Your embassy or consulate	Look it up before you go	Save the emergency number

Tourist police

Many tourist states — including Rajasthan, Goa, Uttar Pradesh (Agra and Varanasi), Kerala and Delhi — have tourist police units, often stationed at major sights, railway stations and ghats. They are used to dealing with foreign visitors, and they can often resolve small disputes (an auto driver refusing to give change, a boatman demanding more than agreed) on the spot. Look for a booth or ask any police officer.

Reporting a crime

For theft, a lost passport, or fraud, file a police complaint (called an FIR — First Information Report — for serious matters). Ask for a copy; you will need it for insurance claims and for a replacement passport. Under Indian law, police can register a "zero FIR" for a cognisable offence regardless of where it happened, so you should not be turned away just because you are at the "wrong" station. Bring your passport, visa, and any evidence: photos, receipts, screenshots, phone numbers, vehicle numbers.

Card fraud and chargebacks

If you were charged by card for something fraudulent — a fake gem deal, a shipped parcel that never arrived, a payment you did not authorise:

1. **Call your card issuer immediately** using the number on the back of your card or in your banking app. Freeze or cancel the card.
2. **Ask about a chargeback.** Card networks have dispute processes for goods not received, goods not as described and fraud. Time limits apply — often a few months, sometimes less — so act fast.
3. **Collect evidence:** receipts, invoices, messages, photos, the shop's name and address, and a police report if you have one.
4. **Write down what happened** while it is fresh: dates, times, names and what was promised.

Cash and UPI payments are much harder to recover, which is one more reason to pay by card for any large purchase.

Lost or stolen passport

Report it to the police, get a copy of the report, and contact your embassy or consulate for an emergency travel document. You will also need to deal with India's immigration authorities for an exit permit or visa transfer in some cases; your embassy will guide you through it.

Leave a review

When it is safe and you are back home, leave an honest, factual review of a business that cheated you — and a glowing one for the people who helped you. Reviews genuinely shape the tourism economy in India, and they protect the next traveller.

Then let it go

The worst outcome of a scam is not the lost money. It is the lost trust that stops you talking to the next friendly stranger — who may be the one who invites you to a family wedding, or shows you the best lassi in town. Learn the lesson, then open your heart again.



Your Pre-Departure Checklist

Tick these off in the week before you fly.

Documents and money

- E-visa applied for **only** at indianvisaonline.gov.in, approved and printed
- Passport valid for at least six months, plus photocopies and a digital copy in secure cloud storage
- Travel insurance with medical cover, checked and saved
- Two debit or credit cards from different banks; bank told about your travel
- Plan for rupees on arrival (airport ATM or exchange counter)
- Checked the current status of UPI One World for foreign visitors

Phone and apps

- Uber, Ola (and optionally Rapido) installed and set up
- IRCTC app installed; account registered if you plan train travel
- Offline Google Maps downloaded for your first city
- First hotel address and phone saved as a screenshot
- 112, 1363, 1930 and your embassy's number saved
- Live location sharing set up with someone at home

Bookings

- First two nights booked through a reputable platform or directly
- Airport pickup arranged, or plan for the prepaid taxi counter
- Hotel messaged with your arrival time
- Any long train journeys booked (Foreign Tourist Quota where available)

Health

- Travel clinic visited (vaccines, malaria advice, medicines)
- Hand sanitiser, ORS sachets, insect repellent, any prescription medicines in original packaging
- Reusable water bottle

In your head

- The one rule: unasked help plus an information gap means slow down
- "Nahi chahiye, shukriya" — practised out loud at least once
- Agree price, duration and route before any ride
- Never shop where you were taken
- Never share an OTP

- The ghats are free



A Note from Vaibhav

When I was young, I used to sit on the steps of the ghats at dusk and watch the boats come in. Every evening I would see the same thing: travellers who had come from the other side of the world, faces lit by the aarti lamps, completely open to the city. And every evening, a few of them would be quietly losing money to men who had learned to read that openness as an opportunity.

I wrote this book because I wanted those travellers to keep the openness and lose the fear. India gave me everything I am. It deserves visitors who leave loving it, not visitors who leave feeling foolish.

If you take only one thing from these pages, let it be this: you are allowed to slow down. The boat will still be there in five minutes. The temple will still be open. The man in a hurry is the one who needs you to hurry. Take a breath, check the price, say "nahi chahiye, shukriya" with a smile — and then go and enjoy one of the most extraordinary countries on earth.

If Varanasi is on your route, I wrote a companion book just for my city: the **Varanasi Insider Guide**, with neighbourhood-by-neighbourhood advice, more real prices, and the places I take my own friends. You can find it at kashigo.in/guide.

My team at KashiGo is also building fixed-price boat experiences on the Ganga with local boatmen from families who have rowed this river for generations. To hear when they open, join the free list at kashigo.in.

Either way — come to Kashi. Walk the ghats at dawn. Drink the chai. Watch the river.

And if a man tells you there is a ticket to walk on the ghats, smile at him for me.

Vaibhav Upadhyay Varanasi



CONTINUE YOUR JOURNEY

More from KashiGo

Varanasi Insider Guide 2026

The practical Varanasi playbook: real prices, all 9 scams, the ghats that matter, food you can trust and a ready-to-use itinerary.

kashigo.in/guide

Kashi Unveiled

The meaning behind the rituals, temples, river and fire — a spiritual traveller's guide to Varanasi.

kashigo.in/shop

Walk the Ghats — Audio Tour

Press play at Assi Ghat and let a local walk you to Manikarnika, story by story.

kashigo.in/shop

Free: Varanasi Scam Cheat Sheet

The one-page list to keep on your phone.

kashigo.in

A SMALL FAVOUR

If this book helped you, a short honest review on the store where you bought it helps other travellers find it — and means the world to a small Varanasi business. Thank you, and har har Mahadev.